
**Unit 1, Option B,
Topic B4: The
European
Witchcraze,
c1580–c1650**

The focus of this topic is on the causes and nature of the witch hunts that peaked in western and central Europe in these years. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which focus exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification. A study of this nature, with a broad spatial as well as temporal focus, relies on the study of particular cases in the context of wider trends.

The bullet points should not each be considered in isolation and students should be aware of the links and interaction between them in establishing key themes. For example, a question on the reasons for the preponderance of women among the accused would draw on the image of the witch (bullet 1 and bullet 3), changes in the social and economic context (bullet 2), the role of the Church and religious attitudes (bullet 3) and the impact of particular situations and individuals (bullet 4).

The first bullet point is focused on the reasons for the witchcraze. Students should be aware of the effect of the religious and economic upheavals of the 16th century in increasing disruption and therefore fear, especially in parts of Switzerland, France, Germany and England, where witch trials peaked from 1580-1650. Students are not expected to have knowledge of events before 1580 but should appreciate that the image of the witch was formed from literature which predates the period. The focus of investigation is on why a witchcraze developed, including the role of the sources from which the image was created and the role of key institutions such as the Church.

The second bullet point focuses on the social and economic context of 1580-1650 and the extent to which it shaped the pattern and outcomes of the witch trials. Students should consider the effects of inflation, changes in the use of land, the decline of customary rights and the impact of these changes on different communities, especially the peasant communities where most witch trials took place. The impact of the wars of religion in France, the Thirty Years War in Germany and the civil war in England is relevant in terms of their disruption of the normal patterns of life and authority. Knowledge of military campaigns is not expected. These issues can be addressed by considering selected case studies and relating them to key conditions. Studies should include evidence of the proportion of women among the accused and suggest some reasons for it.

The third bullet point addresses the nature of the accusations made against witches and students should investigate the nature of the charges usually brought and the process of trial. They should be aware of the widespread use of torture, the nature of 'confessions' and the extent to which these reinforced the stereotype. They should understand the impact of written sources and guides by which witches could be identified. Students are not expected to have wide-ranging knowledge of individual trials in this period, but they will need knowledge of specific examples to illustrate the general pattern and they will need understanding of the extent to which they reflected patterns and stereotypes. For example, they could refer to trials in Ban de La Roche, near Strasbourg in France, in Scotland under James VI and in England during the civil war of the 1640s.